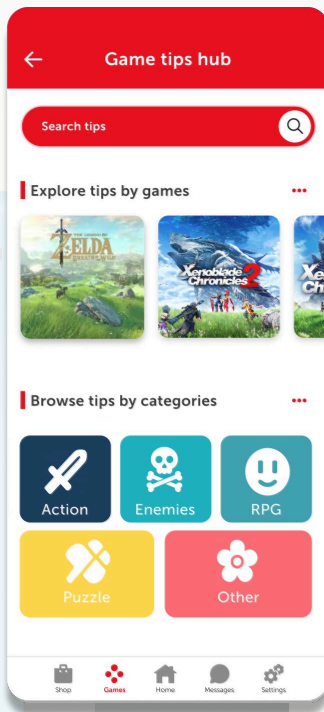


Nintendo Switch app

Helping players move forward without taking away the joy of discovery.



CONTEXT

Self-initiated

DURATION

5-day sprint

ROLE

Solo design

STATUS

Concept
Validated

THE THESIS

Discovery is one of Nintendo's greatest strengths.

But it can also become a barrier when players get stuck.

When players get stuck on a challenge, they leave the ecosystem.

The app can help without getting in the way of the gameplay experience.

Discovery is part of Nintendo's DNA.

But it's also where players can get lost.

THE STRENGTH

Nintendo games are built around discovery, exploration, and autonomy.

THE RISK

When players get stuck, they leave the ecosystem to look for help on YouTube, Reddit, and wikis.

THE TENSION

Too much help can take away the joy of discovery. Doing nothing means losing players outside the ecosystem.

Players already found a solution. It's just not Nintendo's app.

EVIDENCE

Research with 19 Nintendo Switch players.

43% Said the app didn't meet their expectations.

37% Expected in-game tips, not social features.

1 em 5 Had never opened the app.

THE PATTERN

**When they got stuck, they
didn't open the app.**

They went to YouTube.

The app was missing exactly when players needed it most.

O INSIGHT

Jogadores não precisam de mais formas de se conectar. Precisam de ajuda rápida quando ficam presos.

**The challenge wasn't
“adding help to the app.”**

**It was creating a point of intervention
without compromising the game experience.**

This reframed the project from a UX problem
into a positioning problem.

Why the app — not the console — was the right surface.

Three options. Only one preserved the discovery experience.

IN-GAME OVERLAY

Tips inside the game.

- ✗ Breaks the sense of discovery
- ✗ Requires game integration
- ✗ Goes against Nintendo's DNA

SEPARATE APP

A separate app for tips.

- ✗ Just another tool to manage
- ✗ No gameplay context
- ✗ Same friction as YouTube

SWITCH APP

Use the existing companion app.

- ✓ Already connected to the console
- ✓ Works outside the game
- ✓ Offers help without getting in the way of the experience

O PRINCÍPIO

A ajuda deve existir ao lado da experiência, não dentro dela. O app companion era o ponto da Nintendo que melhor respeitava essa lógica.

Help, the Nintendo way. Not the Xbox way.

WHAT COMPETITORS DO

Walkthroughs. Guides. Step-by-step solutions.

More guidance → less discovery.

Players finish faster, but they may also stop playing sooner.

WHAT NINTENDO SHOULD DO

Small hints. Suggestions. Just enough to get unstuck.

Tips that point the way without solving the challenge.

Few spoilers. The player still figures it out on their own.

THE TRADE-OFF

A less explanatory hint feels more Nintendo. The restriction isn't a limitation. **It's the product.**

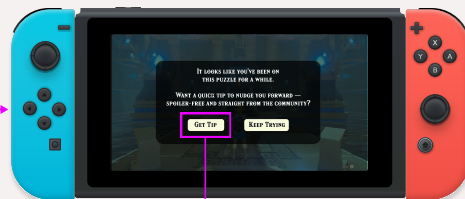
From frustration to a hint in seconds.

Help happens alongside the game — never inside it.



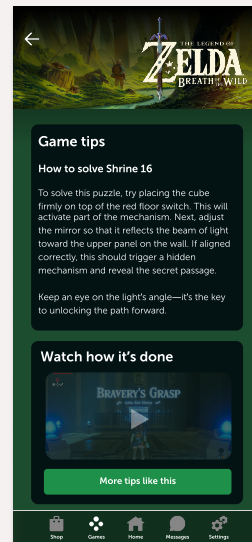
1. The player gets stuck

They try to solve the puzzle, but remain stuck.



2. A suggestion appears

A subtle prompt invites them to open a hint in the app.



3. The hint arrives in the connected app

Contextual, spoiler-free, and available at the right moment.

What I removed to keep the system coherent.

Three decisions that could have made the product worse.

IN-GAME OVERLAY

Tips inside the game.

Would require game-to-game integration and break Nintendo's visual language. The benefit didn't justify the cost.

FULL WALKTHROUGHS

Step-by-step solutions like Xbox Copilot.

They would remove the challenge. Nintendo sells the moment of discovery, not the conclusion.

SOCIAL FEATURES

Community tips, votes, and comments.

They would create moderation challenges and depend on user-generated content. The MVP needed to start with Nintendo-curated content.

Removing features kept the product feeling like Nintendo. Adding everything would have turned it into Xbox.

If contextual help works, the app becomes more than just a companion.

TODAY

A passive app

Friends list, voice chat and news.
Few real reasons to open it.

MVP

A real-time support layer.

Contextual tips when the player gets stuck.
The app starts to have real utility.

NEXT STEP

A personalized guidance layer.

Tips adapted to each player's level and play style.

LONG TERM

A layer of gameplay intelligence.

AI-powered guidance, cross-game progression, and a stronger connection to the ecosystem.

THE BIGGER BET

Tips are just the beginning. The real opportunity is to reposition the app from “social companion” to “gameplay companion.”

How I would measure this and what I would revisit.

HOW I WOULD MEASURE IT

PRIMARY METRIC

Time to recovery

Time between getting stuck and making progress again.

SECONDARY METRIC

External search rate

How often players leave the ecosystem to look for help.

COUNTERWEIGHT

Preserving discovery

The feeling of accomplishment should not disappear.

WHAT I GOT WRONG AT FIRST

It seemed like the obvious solution — but it was the wrong one.

Nintendo's DNA wouldn't survive a UI layer on top of the gameplay.

The constraint led to a better solution: keep the help next to the game, not inside it.

O QUE EU REVISITARIA

- Expand the sample. $n=19$ was directional, not statistically significant.
- Test the timing of the prompt. Showing it too early could compromise discovery.
- Validate with other games beyond Zelda.

Thank you for reading.